



2021

ANNUAL
REPORT



Previous Publications



About the Annual Report

Western Balkans Fund presents its yearly progress on annual basis. As the Regional Projects are the most important tool for the implementation of our objectives, our reports are organized following the Calls for Applications and the project cycle execution. This Report covers the 4th Call of WBF.

Findings and Interpretations

Information and data collection presented in this report were conducted by the staff of the Western Balkans Fund with external contributions. The findings, interpretations, and conclusions expressed in the chapters do not necessarily reflect the views of the Western Balkans Fund's Committee of Senior Officials, or the governments they represent.

Rights and Permissions

The information and other information presented in this report are subject to copyright. WBF encourages dissemination of its knowledge; this work may be reproduced, in whole or in part, for non-commercial purposes as long as full attribution to this work is given. Any queries on rights and licenses, including subsidiary rights, should be addressed to Western Balkans Fund Secretariat.

This report was prepared with the financial support of International Visegrad Fund



Table of Contents

05

Our
Mission

08

Timeline of
key activities

12

Strategic
Path

14

4th Call for
Proposals

54

5th Call for
Proposals

55

6 more
projects
revealed

57

Beyond
Grants

58

Regional
Networking

59

Supporting
Growth

60

Strategic
Partner



OUR MISSION

The Western Balkans Fund (WBF), since its establishment in 2017, envisions a Region at peace with itself, prosperously integrated into its European home.

It envisages a Region where exchange and fruitful, mutually beneficial relations of cooperation between people at all levels and from all walks of life are the norm rather than the exception.

In our five years of existence, we have become a relevant regional player by working closely with regional governments and supporting regional initiatives that put a more transparent bottom-up approach into practice.

As a grant-making organisation, WBF provides direct support to joint regional projects aiming to further strengthen the skills of civil society in the Western Balkans and pursue regional cooperation and reconciliation via a people-to-people approach.

Thanks to the added support of our founders, the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of WB we continue to grow. As a matter of fact, 2021 is the most exceptional year since our establishment.

Moreover, the partnership signed with the European Union made possible a dramatic increase of our financial capabilities, benefiting the Civil Society and Grassroot organisations of the Region.

The proud partnership with the Swiss and Japanese Government support our continued expansion, helping WBF to become much bigger than the grants we provide.

And together with likeminded organisations and other partners, namely the International Visegrad Fund, Central European Initiative, RYCO, Peace Nexus and others, our mission today is more alive than ever before. We are determined to continue in this path and to shape the future of our common home for many years to come.

CALL FOR PROPOSALS

4

AWARDED PROJECTS

105

APPLICATIONS RECEIVED

1,097

WBF

supporting
common
projects
in Numbers

1

Head Office

6

Governing Board
Members

13

Employees

PARTNERSHIPS

4,000+



DIRECT BENEFICIARIES

05

20,000+

WEBSITE VISITS

241,333

FACEBOOK VISITS

642,072

33.3

Average age of
our employees

111,000

And counting, hours of
our life (all combined)
spent at office



Hours in Zoom
meetings

EUROS DISTRIBUTED TO BENEFICIARIES

1,216,000+

Bigger than our grants

Timeline of key activities



Meeting of WB and V4 Ministers of Foreign Affairs in Poland

June 2021/Annual meeting of the Ministers of Foreign Affairs of the V4 and WB6, took place in Poznan, Poland. WBF Executive Director Dr. Gjergji Murra, shared the achievements and future plans, ensuring thus support and sustainability of the Western Balkans Fund. "V4 Group-WB6 political format is a vibrant indicator of the excellent partnership among our two neighborly regions, celebration of the long-standing commitment of the V4 Group and its Member States towards cooperation, stability, development and the European perspective of the WB" –said in his address Mr. Gjergji Murra

Switzerland and WBF agree to boost regional cooperation

July 2021/ Through this new agreement signed in June 2021, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) will be enabled to strengthen its capacities, expand its projects, and increase people to people exchanges and ties in the Western Balkan region. In addition to enhancing the Fund's organizational structure and management, the Swiss support will go towards a more effective funding of common projects and initiatives in the region. The support, in the amount of 950,000 CHF, will also enable WBF to proceed with the strategic plan for the upcoming 5 years.



European Union becomes WBF's strategic partner

July 2021/ Appreciating our unique role in the region, the European Union agreed to co-fund our fourth and fifth Call for Proposals. Because of the added funds, the Western Balkans Fund was able to launch the two biggest Call for Proposals in its history, last November and in May 2022. Also, because of the funding provided in the framework of IPA - Instrument for Pre-Accession Assistance, for the first time in our already rich history, we were able to launch two Call for Proposals in only six months.

4 years of shaping the future of the Western Balkans

September 2021/ Western Balkan Fund held in September 2021 a grand reception, marking the fourth anniversary since its creation. Ambassadors and diplomatic representatives of the WBF Contracting Parties, EU member States, Japan, Switzerland, and members of the civil society attended. The Executive Director, Mr. Gjergji Murra, underlined that WBF has become a unique cooperation mechanism and a good example to regional initiatives. "Our portfolio enabled the creation of networks between 3.400 Civil Society Organizations, education, and Research Institutions, cultural and sports associations, business and local elected bodies, from all over the region, involving more than 10.000 participants".



Regional Conference on Migration and Diaspora

October 2021/ Funded by the Western Balkans Fund, the regional Conference on Migration, Development and Diaspora took place in Tirana in October 2021. The papers presented during the two days event provided important conclusions to the policymakers, allowing them to make informed decisions about the impact of migration and the systemic shock of the Covid-19 pandemic. Brain drain, remittances, return migrants, long-term policy on migration are all topics at the spotlight of the conference.

WBF, IVF and Japan renew their cooperation with FIRE

November 2021/ The Western Balkans Fund, International Visegrad Fund, and Japan agreed to extend their cooperation with a very important project, "FIRE Project, promoting culture of tolerance and mutual respect within two regions (WB6 and V4)". In his speech, Ambassador TAKADA underlined that the financing of FIRE by Japan is a clear sign of his country's commitment towards peace, stability, and development in the region. Mr. Murra added that Japan's support has already improved our lives and that despite the geographical distance, Japan is a great and very close friend to us.



Regional Tour, WBF in each corner of the region

December 2021/ Before the end of 2021, in the framework of the 4th Call for Proposals, the first co-funded by the European Union, Western Balkans Fund members embarked a regional tour of Info Sessions, visiting 12 locations, 2 per Contracting Party. During the Info Sessions, members of our team delivered presentations and met with hundreds of potential applicants, encouraging them to become part of the WBF reconciliation and cooperation experience. Cities visited from November to December 2021 are: Tirana, Korça, Skopje, Bitola, Prishtina, Peje, Belgrade, Novi Sad, Sarajevo, Mostar, Podgorica and Kotor.



Largest regional conference on hate speech and discrimination

March 2022/ 43 guests and almost 80 distinguished participants were part of our 7 panels of the "Promote Culture of Tolerance and Mutual Respect" Conference against hate speech and defamation, held in Tirana from 1-3 March 2022. Otherwise known as the FIRE Conference, organised with the support of the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Visegrad Fund is the largest regional event regarding hate speech in many years. Each panel was livestreamed through the entire continuation of the conference, attracting thousands of views in the platforms shared and generating dozens of recommendations for WBF's Committee of Senior Officials, media and Civil Society Organisations at large.



Grant Awarding Ceremony

April 2022/ In 14 April 2022, 30 winners of the 4th Call for Proposals, the first co-funded by the European Union, received the Grant Award Certificate, handed to them by distinguished guests, Ministers, Ambassadors, European Union representatives, Members of the WBF Governing Body and partners. On behalf of the European Union, a speech was delivered by H.E. Alexis Hupin, Chargé d'Affaires, European Union Delegation to Albania. "EU is actually a project that started based on an idea of good neighbourly relations. If we go fast forward to EU 2022, the turn of events next door, the War on Ukraine, has once more shed light on the importance of good neighbourly relations, respect of sovereignty and territorial integrity", underlined Mr. Hupin.



Another Regional Tour, part of the 5th Call for Proposals

May 2022/ Immediately upon launching the 5 CfP, the Western Balkans Fund team embarked on its regional tour of Info Sessions, visiting 12 locations, 2 per Contracting Party. From 30 May to 9 June 2022, we visited Belgrade, Skopje, Tirana, Podgorica, Sarajevo, Prishtina, Nis, Tetovo, Shkoder, Niksic, Tuzla and Mitrovica. Additionally, for the first time in our history, we piloted 5 Info Days in two Contracting Parties, visiting Mostar, Banja Luka, Zenica, Novi Sad and Kragujevac. From 20-23 June 2022, we completed our dissemination with online Mentorship Sessions, provided in each official language of the Western Balkans.



Six more projects supported thanks to WBF-Swiss Partnership

June 2022/ The cooperation agreement between WBF and Swiss Government yielded direct results on regional cooperation. Thanks to the budgetary core support received, we supported in June six more regional projects. Divided equally between our Contracting Parties, the projects tackle sexual harassment, social inclusion, marginalization, and contribute to best practices exchange and sustainable development through green tourism.





Dr. Gjergj Murra,
Executive Director

This reporting period coincides with the biggest expansion ever experienced in one year by the Western Balkans Fund (June 2021-June 2022). It is the year of the implementation of the 4th Call for Proposal projects, and the year we launched yet another, even bigger, Call for Proposals, the 5th CfP.

It is the year in which we diversified our grant portfolio, becoming a definitive and all-year-round hub for Civil Society Organisations in the Western Balkans. From June 2021, we are constantly expanding, becoming an ever-important regional player, enabling new partnerships and bringing lifelong and sustainable change.

It is also the year in which we grew internally, in numbers and in skills. Five new colleagues have joined the Secretariat since last year on permanent bases. At least 10-12 external experts have been hired to help us perform in different tasks.

We are preparing exciting new features for you that will create deeper bonds and foster further our mission of enhancing people-to-people links in our beautiful region. We are ready to face the new challenges and the next stage of our growth, thanks to the support and determination of our founding parties, our precious partners and the WBF staff, which has been crucial to this leap forward.

It is always a challenge for an organisation to prepare its Annual Report. How does one present the key achievements and essential information in a manner that will not make anyone feel left out? We can only admire the Western Balkans Fund's Team for producing this Report you are about to read, sharing with you a variety the endeavours conducted and achievements accomplished in the service of our Region over the past year. But with that admiration for the commitment of the entire WBF Team led by Executive Director Dr Gjergj Murra, and our gratitude for our partners and their support, certainly comes the respect and the appreciation we all share for the Fund's grantees and their outstanding projects supported over the past years.

The WBF has been set up to help create meaningful partnerships by facilitating and supporting people to people contacts in our Region. The Fund has remained dedicated to these founding principles and serves our Region's civil society, every day, as a beacon of mutual understanding, support and cooperation across the entire Western Balkans. In addition to our longstanding partners from the V4, the Peace Nexus and Japan, continued recognition and support by the European Commission and the Swiss Government gives the Fund new latitude and capacity to better serve the Region – as the 4th and 5th calls to prospective grantees so aptly demonstrate.

Belgrade's 2022 chairmanship of the Fund continued the work of the Skopje chairmanship but also focused on four key objectives of common interest: Continued institutional strengthening of the WBF and staff professionalization; Increasing the regional and international visibility of the WBF; Deepening of cooperation with partners from the EU, Switzerland, Japan and other prospective donors, as well as encouraging the increase of contributions by the six Contracting Parties – the Fund's very founders; and Continuation of cooperation with the International Visegrad Fund and the V4. Belgrade's Chairmanship will continue furthering these goals in close



collaboration with all the Fund's Contracting Parties and, in particular, keep strengthening the Fund as a common institution created to benefit the Western Balkans and all of its inhabitants.

Please remember – what good we do for each other in the Western Balkans, we in fact do for ourselves. It gives me great pride and professional gratification to have been directly involved in the workings of the Western Balkans Fund since its inception a decade ago, and to finally witness the positive effects this benevolent idea is bringing to fruition. I remain hopeful that you, dear reader, will view this Annual Report not only as a simple bureaucratic record of 2022, but that in it you will find inspiration and ideas on how to become involved in collaborating to build a common European future for our Region and its inhabitants, and perhaps even become a Fund's esteemed partner or valued grantee in this shared, brave endeavour!

OUR STRATEGIC PATH

DIVERSE, INNOVATIVE
AND SUSTAINABLE

EUROPEAN VALUES

Since Establishment, we have always emphasized the European future of our Contracting Parties. However, since 2021, with the European Union becoming an official partner of WBF, the European dimension has gained impetus. WBF driven reconciliation and cooperation in the region equals to peace and prosperity for the whole Continent.

The Fund is accomplishing one of the key objectives in becoming a home for aggregated data and evidence demonstrating regional cooperation's impact and value on the communities it supports. WBF constantly has invested in its internal capacities on Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning process and developed tools that yield important data and trying to influence policymaking on a regional scale. Thinking out of the box has allowed the Fund to position itself effectively as an organisation worth of investment from international funding partners.

In 2022, WBF starts with the implementation of the new element of support Diversified Grant Portfolio (DGP) towards joint initiatives that impact regional cooperation in the Western Balkans. Through the diversification of its grant-making, WBF aims to fill some of these gaps and meet more of the growing appetite for people-to-people links, by providing additional opportunities for funding beyond the annual calls. This will enable the Fund to support various types of actors engaging in regional exchange and cooperation, to pursue meaningful opportunities and respond to the demands of civil society and constituents in the Western Balkans. Moreover, with the implementation of Diversified Grant Portfolio, WBF provides access to various actors looking to collaborate and learn on a regional level, in a way that is needs-driven and strategically responsive. The main objective of the Diversified Grants Portfolio (DGP) is to provide meaningful and consistent access to tailored support programs to civil society, educational, cultural and other actors who engage in regional collaboration, to strengthen the regional social infrastructure for cross-border people-to-people cooperation and advance regional interdependence, thus contributing to reconciliation, peace, and stability in the Western Balkans. This objective is backed by the Fund's theory of change and is rooted in the belief that through direct support to a broad variety of stakeholders and a variety of tools, the Fund creates and mobilises both the capacity and the demand for closer regional cooperation and partnership. Thus with the growing scale, visibility and acceptance of successful regional initiatives, coupled with a growing awareness that project support, in part, comes from the Contracting Parties themselves, the notion of regional cooperation will be normalised and celebrated.

INFLUENCING REGIONAL
POLICIES



VISIBILITY AND ADVOCACY FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION

One of the WBF's strategic goals include building productive partnerships with like-minded partners and organizations in order to enable effective promotion, visibility and advocacy for regional cooperation initiatives. To meet these ambitions, WBF in addition to grant-making portfolio, focuses in the integration of partnerships in its programming. WBF builds cooperation with like-minded partners and organizations based on principles of complementarity, transparency, responsiveness, efficiency, accessibility and conflict sensitivity. WBF has expanded its donor portfolio with the European Union, the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation, the Japanese Government including the ongoing partnerships with International Visegrad Fund, RYCO, Peace Nexus.

The unique nature of the Fund as an inter-governmental organisation features prominently in the Fund's promotional strategy. The Fund through promotional activities succeeded to further position in the region as a credible and forthcoming supporter of diverse civil society groups in the region. By advocating the need for more regional cooperation, the Western Balkans Fund is shaping the future on many different levels. Through the data collected within the framework of the 4th Call for Proposals, WBF has learned that 2/3 of the applicants and almost 90% of its beneficiaries are grassroots organisations. Newly established organisations are a unique source of wealth that WBF continue to tap-in in the future.

PRODUCTIVE PARTNERSHIPS WITH LIKE-MINDED ORGANISATIONS

The Fourth Call for Proposals, co-funded by the European Union was launched on 8 November 2021. Deadline for submission of Project Proposals was 27 December 2021. With an overall objective to contribute towards strengthening regional cooperation, and strengthen regional cohesion in the WB6 region, the Call had foreseen three main areas of intervention through which applicants could have submitted their applications: Cultural cooperation, education & scientific exchanges, and sustainable development. The three areas include many other cross-cutting issues, such as gender mainstreaming, equal opportunities, minorities and vulnerable groups, environment and climate change, and others.

The overall indicative amount made available under this Call for proposals was EUR 400.000 EUR, with grants up to 15.000 EUR and projects from 3-10 months.

The evaluation process of the received projects started in January 2022, lasting until the end of February. In March, applicants were officially notified of their application status. The awarding ceremony and mentoring session took place 14-15 April, with implementation starting immediately after.

4th Call for Proposals

Evolution of the size of our Call for Proposals

1 CfP
240.000 Euros
2 CfP
260.000 Euros
3 CfP
260.000 Euros
4 CfP
400.000 Euros
5 CfP
500.000 Euros (expected)

IN NUMBERS

207

Eligible Applications

347

Total Applications

800+

New Partnerships

ONLINE GRANT MANAGEMENT SYSTEM



Online Grant Management System (OGMS) is a transparent and innovative tool, launched at the beginning of the 4 CfP. Thanks to the OGMS, every application becomes fully automatized, contrarily to 1-3 CfP, where applications were received through email or post. With the OGMS we stopped accepting applications through email or post, reducing the burden on the applicant and improving our capabilities as a reliable and growing international organisation.

FUNDS REQUESTED

4.223.614 €



FUNDS PROVIDED

400.000 €

For over a month, the WBF Team visited all the Contracting Parties, meeting potential applicants and encouraging Civil Society Organisations and stakeholders to become part of WBF's experience.

Info Sessions of the 4 CfP featured distinguished guests, including a representative from EU Delegation in all the capital cities visited. Spread equally to better represent the spirit of the WBF, Info Sessions took place in Tirana, Korçë, Skopje, Bitola, Prishtina, Pejë, Belgrade, Novi Sad, Sarajevo, Mostar, Podgorica and Kotor.

Thanks to the collaboration established with the national press agencies and other news outlets, the opening of the Call was published in many languages and networks all over the region. News about WBF was featured for the first time in the Western Balkans platform.

In Facebook and Instagram, from 8 November to 27 December 2021, Western Balkans Fund page received a reach of 90.000 individuals, and a record of over 250.000 impressions.

The webpage registered a growth of over 230%, compared to the same period one year before. Once again, the WBF Partnership Platform revealed itself as a useful tool for matchmaking, helping over 60 organisations to identify partners for their projects.

AWARDING CEREMONY & WORKSHOPS

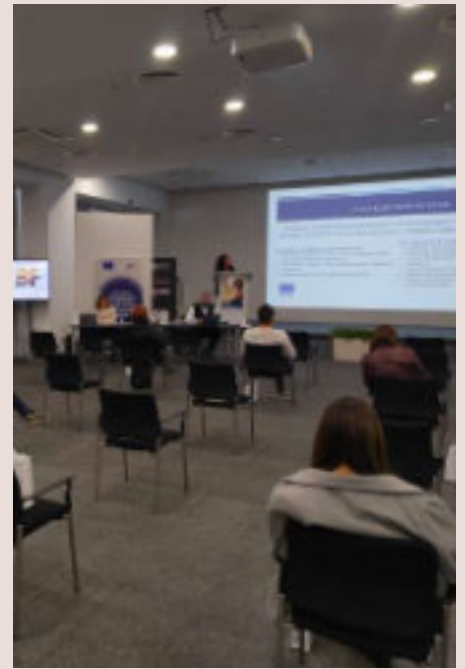
30 winners of the 4th Call for Proposals, the first co-funded by the European Union, received the Awards on 14 April 2022. The appreciation diploma was handed to them by distinguished guests, Ministers, Ambassadors, European Union representatives, Members of the WBF Governing Body and partners. During their stay in Tirana, grantees received also 3 days of mentoring, regarding general expectations, MEL, visibility, finance, contractual obligations, etc.

ELIGIBLE BENEFICIARIES

- Civil Society Organizations
- Associations
- Foundations
- Non-for profit organizations
- Regional networks
- Local and regional public entities
- Associations of local and regional public entities
- Business associations
- Business cluster
- Agriculture Association
- Chamber of Commerce
- Tourism Association
- Universities
- School
- Library
- Research Centre
- Academy of science/music/art.
- Museum
- Art Gallery
- Theatre
- Library
- Sport Association
- Other

4th Call for Proposals in Motion





15

PROJECTS OF CULTURAL COOPERATION

Culture, Heritage and Sports have been recognized as areas that have a great regional cooperation potential. They are not only vital to the overall societal developments, but have a significant advantage in serving as a multiplier effect to reach far more people than those who directly participate in cultural/sport events directly. It is also perceived that cultural events specifically are highly valuable in affecting regional cooperation, as the region shares a lot of cultural and traditional values that could bring people closer.

Project	Lead Applicant
1. Media and art in service of reconciliation	Association Kulturanova
2. Balchestra	Artlink
3. In Search of Our Musical Roots	Umjetnost džeza-JazzArt
4. Contemporary Fortresses of Culture: Boka, Trebinje, Novi Sad	Don Branko Subtega Foundation
5. Intercultural dialogue for joint past narrative	Youth initiative for Human rights Montenegro
6. Support to women's efforts in building regional democracy	Kosovo Institute of Media and Communication
7. I love Balkan	NGO Lady
8. Regional Evenings of Cultural Heritage	Ensemble "VESELIN MASLESA"
9. Female Leadership Camp	Udruženje Otvorene zabavne škole
10. Messages from the Past	Zenica City Museum
11. Common Cultural Heritage: Interregional research and educational practices	Center for Prehistoric Research
12. Protection of National and Cultural Heritage through sustainable tourism in geoparks	Stena Stenae
13. Art for Reconciliation	Tulla Culture Center
14. Strengthening intercultural dialogue as a tool for youth-to-youth connection and good neighborly relations in the region	AFCR
15. QAR (Qendra Artizanale Rinore)	Tirana Ekspres

Association Kulturanova

Prerarodoviceva, 123/231; Petrovaradin, Novi Sad



"Media and Art in service of Reconciliation" project contributes to CSO cooperation in the WB6 region by working on reconciliation by producing new narratives among young people. During the ten-day training in Bosnia and Herzegovina, participants from Serbia and Kosovo* worked on making media analyses of narratives published on media portals in WB Region.

This specific project combats prejudices and existing stereotypes that develop from not knowing the full facts or the true extent and complexity of Western Balkan's sensitivities and history. In addition to providing these young people with a critical insight into media content, specifically regarding the Srebrenica Massacre, the project also demonstrates the growing importance of media literacy.



2 partners

ARTPOLIS- Art and
Community Center
Association "Nasa Djeca" Zenica

18-26 yo

Target Audience, young people,
bands, festival visitors (including
experts and artists), media.



*This designation is without prejudice to positions on status, and is in line with UNSCR1244 and the ICJ Opinion on the Kosovo Declaration of Independence.



ARTLINK

KNEZ MILETINA, 1,11000. BEOGRAD



The regional orchestra of ArtLink provides progress in different areas through a common agenda and platform - culture, tourism, sustainable development. As a follow-up of several previous regional initiatives and platform realized by ArtLink and its partners, and following the European agenda and program "Festival Cities", the project combines those two innovative programs with the idea to develop a regional structure that will enable regional cooperation and reconciliation, as well as a structural positioning of the Region on multiple levels. All of this adds other layers to the already very successful experience of creating a unique orchestra, combined with talented musicians from all over the Western Balkans

3 1000+
PARTNERS AUDIENCE

Artplus
Association for affirmation of
Musical culture MUSA
International Peace Centre

Artists, festivals and festival audiences,
cities and their inhabitants, young leaders
and women leaders in cultural sector,
tourists officers and tourists from the
region as well as tourists from abroad,
citizens.



Courtesy of Jazz Art

JAZZ
ART

jazz
art

Rista Stijovića 2, 81000 Podgorica



PARTNERS

Academy of Music at Goce
Delcev University, Stip

Cultural Association Syri Blue

Academy of Arts at University of
Banja Luka

Faculty of Music, University of
Arts in Belgrade

This project contributes to regional cooperation, and strengthens regional cohesion in the WB6 region through creation of new jazz and contemporary music written by young composers from the WB Region and performed by an ensemble of young musicians-students. "In Search of Our Musical Roots" is in a way a continuation of Balkan Youth Jazz Orchestra (BYJO), a project which was a grantee of WBF 3th Call. The continuation and expansion of that project is important as a support for the development of joint musical creativity of young Balkan musicians, giving them a chance to continue to work together, through special guidelines and research topics connecting their musical roots and new musical expressions. This will also lead to closer inter-regional cooperation between composers and players. More performances through the region will popularize jazz and contemporary music among youth audiences, bridging the cultures and bringing them closer.

ENGAGED
AUDIENCE

Young musicians, cultural organizations, music
conservatories and art and music academia



Stari Grad, 456, 85330, Kotor

Don Branko Sbutega Foundation



Project "Contemporary Fortresses of Culture: Boka, Trebinje, Novi Sad" increases awareness of the richness of cultural heritage in our Contracting Parties. By realizing activities that encourage dialogue, and promote protection, valorization, sustainable usage, and management of participative and integrated approaches of tangible and intangible cultural heritage, the project aims to explore and analyze opportunities and challenges of the (to a large extent) forgotten, neglected and dissonant Austro-Hungarian heritage in Boka, Trebinje and Novi Sad, while at the same time highlighting its potentials in terms of sustainable development and development of regional cooperation and cohesion.



Partners
Društvo građana Podbare
"Almašani"
Udruga građana
"Mostovi" Trebinje

Target
Cultural heritage
professionals, creative
and cultural experts and
workers and NGO sector
representatives

YIHR MONTENEGRO

Studentska ulica 21/a, br. 5. Podgorica



FILM NEGATIVE



FILM NEGATIVE



FILM NEGATIVE



FILM NEGATIVE

The aim of this project is to contribute to reconciliation process in Western Balkans by empowering the youth. This is done by encouraging them to engage actively in process of facing the past, fighting impunity for war crimes and apply critical thinking in narratives of the 90s through intercultural dialogue and cross-border cooperation in the field of transnational justice. By setting the focus on the intercultural dialogue among youth coming from different ethnic, religious and national background in WB, the project produces intercultural cooperation that directly impacts the reconciliation process on the most dividing topics within the society of Contracting Parties. Thus, it aims increasing knowledge, awareness and readiness of youth to get involved intercultural cooperation on most fragile topics that divide communities and that are burdened with stereotypes and prejudices. The first step in achieving this aim is to increase capacities of youth to understand, deal with and apply critical thinking on narratives related to the past of 90s wars, enabling this way the process of facing the past through intercultural dialogue established on these topics.

PARTNERS

Youth Initiative for Human rights Serbia
Youth Initiative for Human rights B&H

TARGET

Youth, students of law/political sciences, young journalists

KOSOVO INSTITUTE FOR MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION

Street B, no. 210, 10000 Prishtina



The initiation of the project “Support to women's efforts in building regional democracy” is a must in order to improve the capacities and enhance support to women population in Western Balkan region. Moreover, the role of media is crucial in supporting gender equality and women’s empowerment since it is widely perceived that financial resources linked to political interests restrict some editorial decisions and that sometimes these interests may not align with the gender equality movement or with support for women candidates. By uniting leaders and policy makers from all around the region, such project provided important insights and a list of recommendations already addressed to relevant institutions.

PARTNERS

Gradjanski Glas
Mediator Room

TARGET

Young female politicians
part of local and national
assembly’s coming from all
six contracting parties

NGO Lady

Rr. Agim Rramadani 527 10000 Prishtina

Partners

1. Observatory for Children and Youth Rights YIHR
2. Poduzetnice IN
3. Association of Women Entrepreneurs of Montenegro
4. Macedonian Women's Rights Centre – Shelter Centre Skopje
5. Association of Women Filigran Art



Audience

Women entrepreneurs of all age, ethnicity and race, aspiring female entrepreneurs, students and other women coming from Western Balkan region.

The initiation of this joint initiative contributes to improving the livelihood of families by increasing women's access to economic opportunities, which in turn will benefit their own families and the families of their employees. This will include women entrepreneurs affected by the conflict as well as women entrepreneurs with disabilities. The project represents a women-specific initiative to address gender inequalities in the small enterprise sector. It combines gender equality promotion with enterprise development. Specifically, it envisages direct technical support to local actors thereby enabling them to: a) Improve the business environment for women entrepreneurship and b) Improve access to markets for women entrepreneurs.

Ensemble of folk dances and songs "VESELIN MASLESA"

Aleja Svetog Save 1678000 Banja Luka



The overall objective of the project "Regional evenings of cultural heritage" is to promote cultural cooperation and exchange among folklore ensembles in Western Balkans.

Folklore ensembles are artistic non-profit societies, guardians of tradition and national cultural, who could enhance good neighbourly relations and reconciliation as well as to promote culture heritage.



1000+ beneficiaries

Members of all three folklore ensembles - in total circa 1000 members of all ages, out of which around 1/3 are children under age of 16, Custodians of cultural heritage (orchestras, drama sections, literary sections, art sections, museums, etc.), Folklore schools, Public institutions that could support extension of the project in the future.

Together with

Academic Cultural Artistic
Association "SPANAC"

The Folklore Ensemble of dance and song "Skopje"

Open Fun Football School



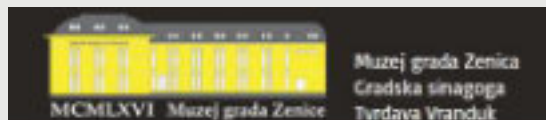
"Female Leadership Camp" mobilized young women with sports background, making them engage in 'Leadership for women' learning process. The final aim: To build their capacity (action-learning) to independently organize sport-for-change activities in their local communities, thereby providing them with an "anchor" in their local communities ultimately enhancing their life opportunities and resilience. As a byproduct, enhancing mobility of young women across the region and networking facilitated an interregional platform of young women, who want to become future leaders through sports.

Partners

Fudbalski klub Breznica
Sportsko udruženje Otvorene zabavne
škole fudbala

Target Groups

30 young women aged 18-35, coming from
local communities across the region



ZENICA CITY MUSEUM

Muham eda Seida Serdarevića bb, Zenica

Through a series of workshops with children, the “Messages of the Past” project explored the many similarities that we share in our common region. During the workshops, the children learned many important information, but they were also taught about gender equality and the European future of our Contracting Parties. The implemented project included also many grassroots organisations from the Western Balkans Region, eager to participate more in regional cooperation project on social, cultural, scientific and economic topics, including cross-cutting issues such as gender equality, disability inclusiveness, good neighbourly relations and reconciliation





Center for Prehistoric Research



"Common Cultural Heritage: Interregional research and educational practices" brings together experts and students from three different CP. All of them are well known in their work and have been collaborating on several occasions. Working as a team in this project, participants will highlight the common prehistoric cultural heritage in the aforementioned CPs and through various actions will promote these principles among local communities, national representatives, young people and prominent specialists in humanities.



Partner 1:
Institute of
Archaeology, Academy
for Albanian Studies



Partner 2
Faculty of Philosophy –
Belgrade



Target Audience



The project has several target groups that are directly or indirectly involved in the cultural heritage research, protection, and promotion. Above all the project will highlight women experts dealing with prehistory. Also a major group will be students from Albania, Serbia and North Macedonia which are the future of cultural heritage studies, that will be trained to understand its interregional features and to perceive its cohesion. Besides them, also the local communities, minorities, and official representatives will be incorporated in the project as they are in constant interaction with the cultural heritage landscape.





Stena Stena e

Marshal Tito bb 1442 Demir Kapija

Sustainable tourism is now an emerging focus for the West Balkan Region that is looking to diversify their economy and boost its respective tourism industries. This region possesses a great richness and diversity of both natural and cultural heritage which is not valorised, promoted and affirmed on high level to the potential visitors. By conserving and presenting its natural and cultural attractions in an exciting and easily-accessible manner, the WB countries can look to capture new visitors and market segments. As proposed by UNWTO, sustainable tourism ensures a high level of satisfaction and meaningful experience to the tourists, while raising awareness on sustainability and environmental issues. Following the overall objective of this call, project aims to strengthen the collaboration and promote the unique identity of WB region through a broad range of activities related to sustainable form of tourism. Specific activities will be related to four pilot areas in four WB countries (North Macedonia, Serbia, Montenegro and Albania) which are protected areas.

In partnership with
Municipality of Demir Kapija
Department of Geography and
tourism, Novi Sad
Bird of Albania
Park Piva

Target Audience
Stakeholders of the tourism industry: tourism organizations,
travel agencies dealing with receptive tourism activities, tour
guides, relevant NGOs, relevant governmental bodies, nature
environmental protection institutions, nature protected
areas and academia

Tulla Culture Center

Art for Reconciliation is the project idea introduced by TULLA Cultural Centre (from Albania) and Urban Development Centre (from Serbia) and PriFilmFest (from Kosovo) that introduced new views on cooperation and reconciliation through arts. Joint initiative titled Art for Reconciliation is initially designed in a period when there are clear consequences of a global crisis that has changed the norms and standards of our realities. The art plays an essential role in the management of the stress caused by the COVID-19, while art in general was left behind since the pandemic redefined vision and change the way of doing art. Art for Reconciliation will introduce new way of reconciliation through engagement of young artists in contemporary arts and digital. Storytelling will disclose hidden histories and alternative narratives. The concept of this joint initiative it is meant to be unsettling: It challenges most commonly understood notions of belonging,



Target Group

Up to 20 young artists and/or multimedia studies from given CP from the age between 20 to 26 years older and local community

Centar za Urbani
Razvoj
PriFilm Festival



*CoverPicture, courtesy of Tulla

Albanian Foundation for Conflict Resolution and Reconciliation of Disputes



Rruga "Him Kolli", Pallati P.F.Trade,Nr.5, Tiranë

Final
Beneficiaries

18

teachers and students of
the selected schools

365

students and teachers
part of workshops

195

students and teachers
preparing the art work

170

students online

450

students engaged in the
platform

1198

Total Beneficiaries



The project includes a set of activities with the overall objective of contributing to the meaningful participation of youth from Albania, North Macedonia, and Bosnia and Herzegovina, in promoting intercultural dialogue as means of building good neighborly relations, reconciliation and peace through a collaborative approach and joint activities.



In cooperation with
Association Interactive Education and ResourceNetwork –IMOR
Nansen Dialogue Centre Mostar



Tirana Ekspres

Rruga Hoxha Tahsin, pranë sheshit Avni Rustemi, Tiranë

In Partnership with
Art Lab BiH
Ngo Creative and
Active in NMK



This project united talented peoples with disabilities and empowered them through training on artisanal work and by providing a direct link to the market. Thanks to the project, a unique group of wonderful and extremely talented people learned skills that help them become self-reliant economically and even direct contributors to their families. On top of that, the regional dimension of the project made possible to create a network, that will be active in promoting over the long-term people with disabilities in the region.

Target Audience

Persons with disabilities that will be the main beneficiaries of the project

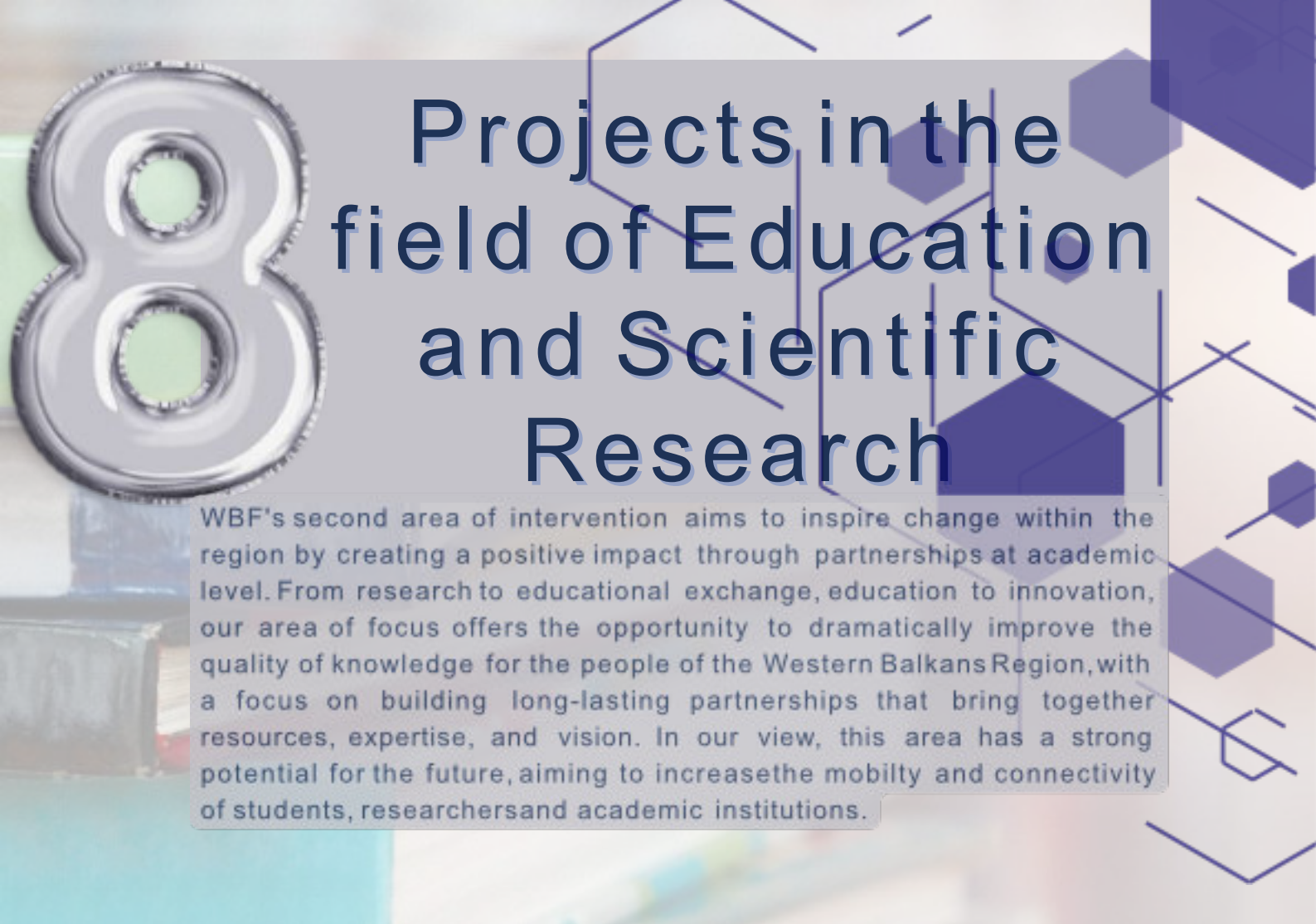
Organizations working with persons with disabilities

Public Institutions that have in their scope of work, persons with disabilities

Media, promoting the project

Local community





Projects in the field of Education and Scientific Research

WBF's second area of intervention aims to inspire change within the region by creating a positive impact through partnerships at academic level. From research to educational exchange, education to innovation, our area of focus offers the opportunity to dramatically improve the quality of knowledge for the people of the Western Balkans Region, with a focus on building long-lasting partnerships that bring together resources, expertise, and vision. In our view, this area has a strong potential for the future, aiming to increase the mobility and connectivity of students, researchers and academic institutions.

Project	Lead Applicant
1. Balkan Short Film Network	UG Akademska Scena
2. Mainstreaming Humanity in Western Balkans: From Education to Reconciliation	Faculty of Political Science, Uni. of Belgrade
3. Birds Without Borders (BWB)- Phase II	Center for Protection and Research of birds
4. Enhancing Regional Cooperation of Young Researchers on Migration & Development	GERMIN
5. The green valley	IPSIA BIH
6. Transitional justice through joint educational approach	ANIM - History Teacher Association of Macedonia
7. Ohrid TrcaT Athletic Camp 2022	Athletic Club Ohrid trcaT
8. Hello Neighbour: Knowing the region through internships and exchange	Impact Center

UG AKADEM SKA SCENA

Vuka Karadžića 14/8, Bajina Bašta



Cover Picture, from the Basta Fest festival. Courtesy of the lead-applicant

The project promotes intercultural dialogue on a local level in Struga (North Macedonia), Ulcinj (Montenegro) and Bajina Basta (Serbia), since smaller communities tend to be more closed and intolerant towards sensitive topics are perceived as unpleasant or unwanted. By providing knowledge and support to young filmmakers to develop, produce and disseminate their collaborative works, the project steers public debate on a local level and raises awareness of citizens, creating a fresh impetus for making a positive switch in public's attitudes towards gender equality, climate change, reconciliation, human rights (including rights of ethnic, religious minorities, and other marginalized groups) and democratic values. The action is jointly designed based on the extensive diverse experience of project consortium members.

PA RTN ERS

Association for cultural affirmation
Bager Genesis 2.0
NVO Ja djelujem

TA RGET

Young film directors and
producers from WB6, young
film makers and audience.



Faculty of Political Sciences University of Belgrade

JOVE ILIĆA 165, 11000 BELGRADE

The central activity of this project is the organization of a six-day joint forum gathering participants from different Contracting Parties. Students, university professors and practitioners will convene in order to discuss topics related to humanity perceived from different disciplines - transitional justice, regional reconciliation, migration, human rights, conflict analysis and the role of international organisations. The project fosters intra-regional mobility and youth networking, as well as a more proactive approach of young generations towards topics of concern in their domestic contexts. This forum provides students with new knowledge and skills, professors will improve their teaching and research capacities, and practitioners will gain the opportunity to show how to put theoretical frameworks into practical use.

Students, professors and practitioners as well as wider public.

Humanistic Studies of the
University of Donja Gorica

Belgrade International
Law Circle

Faculty of Political
Sciences University of
Sarajevo





Center for Protection and Research of Birds



Velje brdo 3581412Podgorica

Birds Without Borders-BWB expresses not-tied-country borders nature of the bird species migration and need for joint interventions in order to contribute to the preservation and valorization of birdlife diversity in the Adriatic Flyway migration route. The project strengthens the capacities of NGO partners related to the protection and monitoring of bird species through research camps. Additionally, this project improves the knowledge and fill in the remaining gaps concerning the avian biodiversity, and conservation needs along the Adriatic Flyway by contributing to the scientific evidence of migrating birds using the Adriatic Flyway.



Partners

Bird Protection and Study
Society of Serbia
Albanian Ornithological Society

Targets

Environmental NGOs in WB
countries, biology students,
protected area managers





Tringë Smajli, 49/1, 7th floor 10000 Prishtina

Courtesy of Germin



PARTNERS

Centre for Support of Local and Regional Development CeP

Association ESTIMA

The Western Balkans have a particular relevance in the study of migration in its various forms, including labour migration, high-skilled migration, forced migration, diaspora formation and return migration—all of which are present in this region. And yet this region as a whole remains under-investigated by migration scholars and researchers. This special project represents an effort to reduce this gap in policy-relevant research. Given that the whole region is facing the same phenomenon, the best way to react to it is through regional initiatives, which aim to create opportunities and space for joint action. The idea of a fellowship that aims to meet the demand for pragmatic and thoughtful responses to the challenges and opportunities that large-scale migration in Western Balkan countries presents to communities and institutions in a globalized world.

TARGET AUDIENCE

Civil Society Organizations focused on migration & development, research, academic institutions in Kosovo, Montenegro, and North Macedonia.

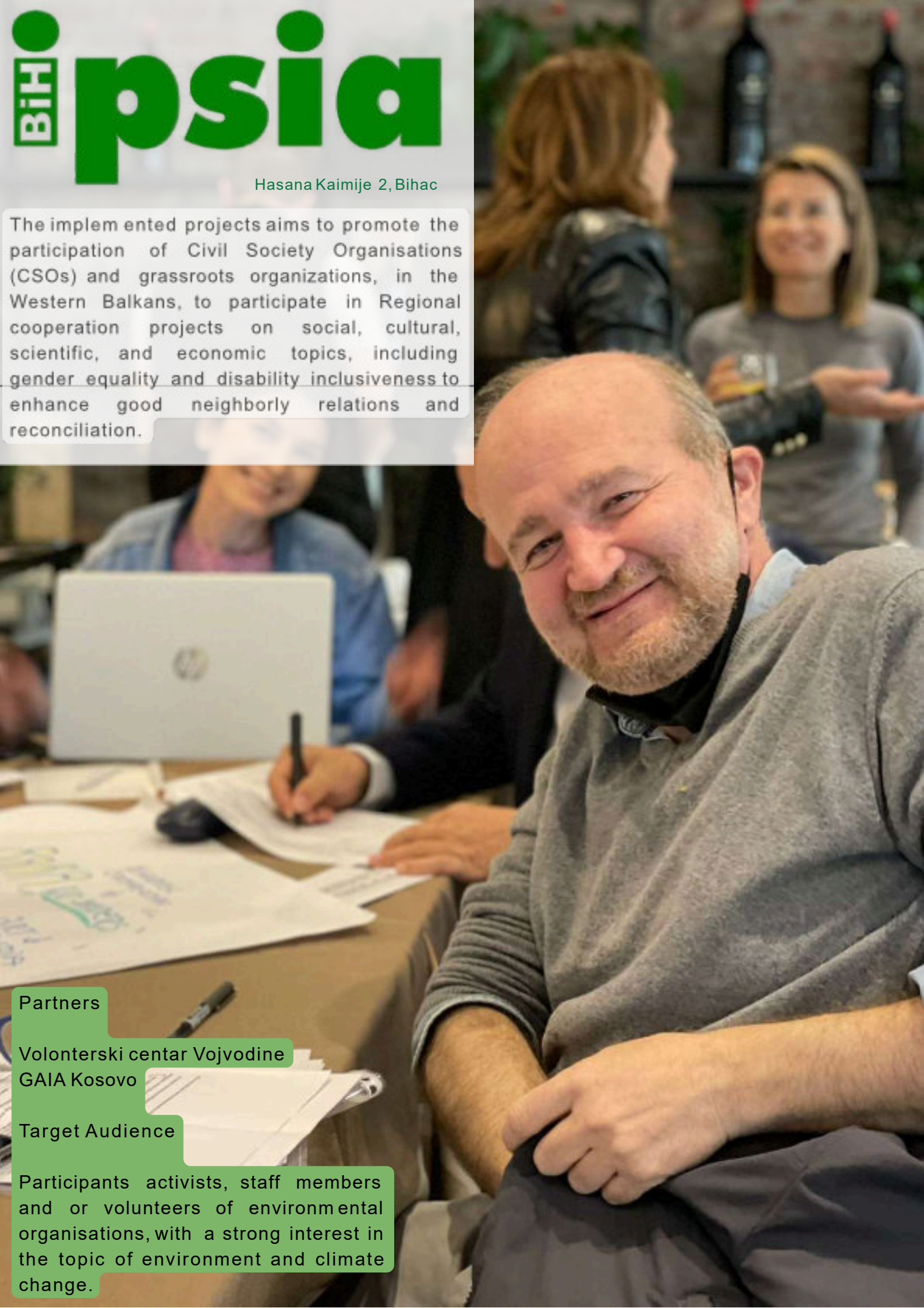
The implemented projects aims to promote the participation of Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) and grassroots organizations, in the Western Balkans, to participate in Regional cooperation projects on social, cultural, scientific, and economic topics, including gender equality and disability inclusiveness to enhance good neighborly relations and reconciliation.

Partners

Volonterski centar Vojvodine
GAIA Kosovo

Target Audience

Participants activists, staff members and or volunteers of environmental organisations, with a strong interest in the topic of environment and climate change.



ANIM - History

Teacher Association of Macedonia

Volkovo 60, Skopje



The project addresses issues related to the cooperation between professional organizations of history teachers in the Western Balkans region which was existent for almost two decades. During the recent period, they boldly and decisively improve their cooperation in the field of improving and modernizing the teaching of history in order to transform it into a tool of cooperation. Project's main focus is the promotion and consolidation of regional cooperation as a very positive impact on stability and major benefit for our societies, aware that this is a very responsible and delicate job whose results are not visible in the short term, but they represent a serious investment for the future.

4 partners

EUROCLIOHIP BiH - History teachers association in Bosnia and Herzegovina

DI Euroclio - Association for Social History,

HIP MONT - Association of history educators of Montenegro

SHMHK - History Teachers Association of Kosovo

300+ beneficiaries

The main target group will be teachers working in primary and secondary schools, teaching subjects with points of contact with the transitional justice process, such as History, Civic Education, and Ethics. An estimated additional 300 teachers will be involved in discussions and joint activities via in-person teacher training, social media outreach, and online activities. Students will indirectly benefit from the project as the ultimate beneficiaries of an increased quality of education conducted by the teachers directly benefiting from the project.



Ohrid Trcat

Dame Gruevb11/7 6000 Ohrid

In Partnership with
Association Zdrav Zivot
- Kinezis
Trail Running Albania
AK Hajduk-Maraton
AK Rabotnicki



Democracy is something children learn as they develop from infancy through adolescence. A child whose active engagement with the world has been encouraged from the outset will be a child and citizen of the world who is more likely to value his or her own opinion and beliefs, and the opinions and beliefs of others. Through this unique project, we aim to enable children's experiences of participation in their homes, schools, and communities including the importance of the relational context, not only in formal structures and support their participation based on notions of competence and voice. The activities contribute to recognizing and facilitating children's informal and social participation as well as new forms of democratic processes being developed by children to address the possibility of direct engagement of children.



Target Audience

60 school age children from four WB who are in some way involved in sports activities in the respective partner activities

Interview with Johan Piluri | Issue 2

June, 2022

Hello Neighbour Impressums

"I would have stayed and worked in Bosnia and Herzegovina for a year. Ask me again after that year. Maybe I want to come back home. Which home? Now I know that anywhere in Balkan is my home"



Photo from traveling to Tuzla in Bosnia and Herzegovina (Johan and Alja)

About the intern

Johan Piluri comes from Korça, Albania. He is representative of Impact Centre Tirana. His host organization was Media Promo Info. For the internship period he was placed at Tuzla, a neighbourly city in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

The project according to Johan

Hello Neighbour is a project where three Balkan countries (Albania, Montenegro, and Bosnia & Herzegovina) have to send students from age 18-25 to have a 2-week internship where they will learn about their host country, the city they are staying in, the working-culture of the organisation they are working in, and to have an amazing experience! I am part of it because I like to experience new things in life, to embark on new challenges, and I like to network with people who are not only from my homeland. It is going to be an amazing experience for me, work wise and fun!

IMPACT

Impact Centre | www.impactcentre.org | info@impactcentre.org

Up to 150 youth in three countries will share their experience in open days, where the interns will be the main speakers and share their experience.

Up to 1000 youth will be exposed online to the posts and activities to be published by the interns and the project, giving thus the opportunity to learn about each-other through this mobility.

Up to 1150
beneficiaries

The regional cooperation in the Western Balkans is one of the most positively perceived approaches in the region. People from all Balkan countries are thrilled to see initiatives, exchanges and joint programs that help them know each-other from different approaches and that bring countries and people closer. Outside the region, people from the Balkan Diaspora find it comfortable and easy to befriend, to socialize, to work together, to help each-other's study journeys, businesses and companies, to become good friends and feel a sense of commonality in each-other's company. This is due to the excessive number of mutual elements that people from the Balkans identify in each-other once we're out of the region. The Impact Centre project increases regional cooperation in education field, contributing directly to enhanced cooperation and Reconciliation process.



Projects in the field of Sustainable Development

Sustainable development prioritizes promotion and enabling of socio-economic cooperation, including but not limited to employment, environment, local economic development that directly contribute to the regional cooperation and development. As a people to people driven Fund, WBF is focused through this area of intervention to build and foster regional cooperation through small-scale projects that present "pre" conditions for short, medium and/or long-term impact by identifying and accelerating breakthrough solutions, ideas and dialogue,

Project

1. Promoting the Western Balkans greenways network

2. Partnership for mothers and babies

3. Game Jam

4. Regional Investment Promotion

5. Cross Border Co-working Cooperation (CBCC)

6. Leap to success

7. Creating a cross-border network for socio economic sustainability through protection of nature

Lead Applicant

Yugo Cycling Campaign

Gradjanski Glas
Crne Gore

IPKO Foundation

Chamber of Trade
and Industry in Kosovo

INTERA Technology
Park

AGORA

FLAG

YUGO CYCLING CAMPAIGN

Vršačka 8, Zem un 11080 Belgrade



Cover Picture, courtesy of Yugo Cycling Campaign

This project promotes cycling in the WB and attempts successfully to coordinate efforts in three Contracting Parties, with the purpose of creating a common cycling network. The idea is to transfer the abandoned railway lines into so called greenways, i.e. specific infrastructure exclusively for cycling and hiking. The region is covered by fifth Euro Velo Routes (in this case the region is considered much bigger than the WBR), where there already organized events like "Cycling the West Balkan Triangle", cycling along the Via Dinarica known as the White Trail, etc. But unlike the West European standards, the current trails through WBR are using the existing roads for motor vehicles, without specially designated infrastructure for cycling and walking. Thus, the main relevance of this project is to offer a possibility for transforming some motorized vehicles infrastructure (in this case railways), into greenways.

PARTNERS

NU Nature Lovers

The Mountain Biking
Association –MTBA

TARGET

National authorities, tourists' operators, Sport organizations, NGOs dealing with environment and climate changes, Citizens, particularly those close to the new greenways, Local entrepreneurs and services, Schools and universities, Women's rights organizations, International community (tourists), Local authorities and stakeholders.

Gradjanski Glas Montenegro



Project is aimed to support both mothers and babies through creating a comfortable space in public for breastfeeding, bottle-feeding and changing - whenever the babies need it. That means setting up functional benches with inbuilt changing tables that would facilitate their daily life needs. The impact/results project aims to achieve is to raise awareness of the importance of breastfeeding, as the best and healthiest way to feed babies, and to normalize breastfeeding in the public once and for all. And to support society to become more friendly, encouraging and supportive to all mothers and babies and at the same time cities across the region and Western Balkans to become places with better living conditions for families.



Beneficiaries

Mothers and babies, local communities in Bar, Shkodër and Trebinje

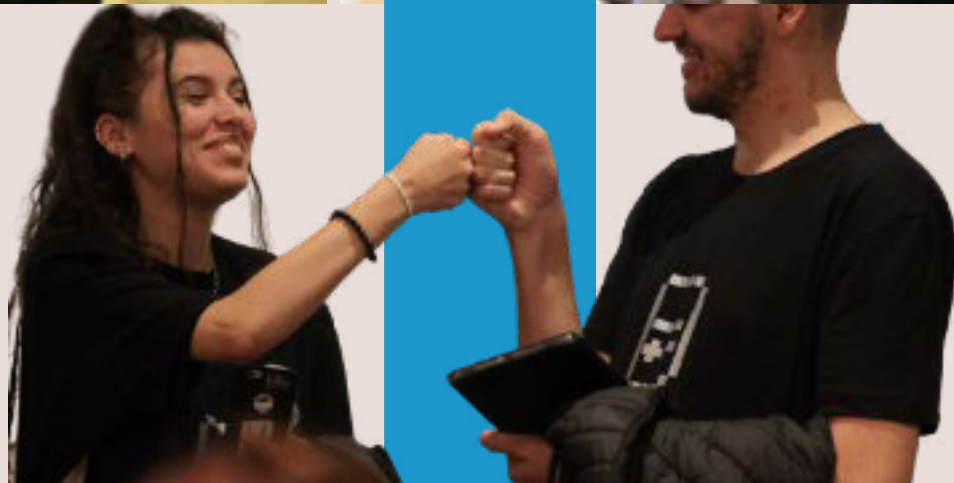
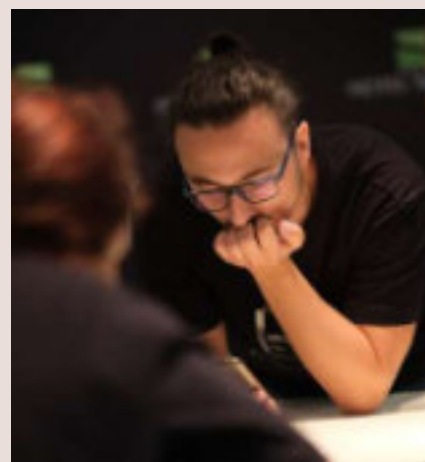
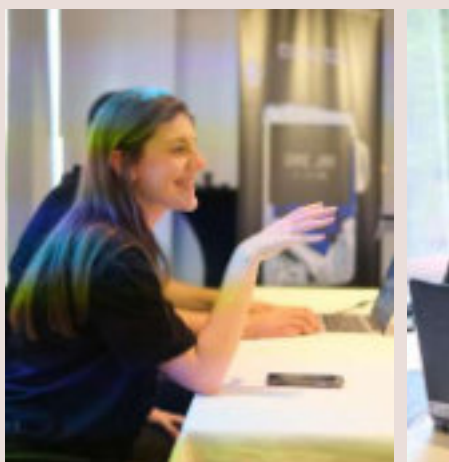
Together with

Fondacija Ženski centar Trebinje
Gruaja tek Gruaja



IPKO Foundation

Enver Gjerqeku, nr 20 10000 Prishtina



Partners

Cyber Security, Corporate
Security and Crisis
Management Initiative –
C3I

WIT Albania Center



Target Audience

Students ages 18- 24
yearsold coming from
three Contracting Parties

This project addresses issues related to the importance of creating new job opportunities for game developers in Kosovo and enable the exchange of experiences and knowledge between youth of Kosovo, Albania and North Macedonia. Action was developed through empowerment of game developers to further enhance their skills in game development with a focus on training female leaders in order to ensure an easier transition to the job market. The project reach out to 2000 students on the project through different ways outreach (live and online), about 60 young people per session/240 participants per year while 100 young people will benefit from Game Development Courses.

Chamber of Trade and Industry Kosovo

This project contributes to the regional cooperation, and strengthen regional cohesion in the WB6 region since it brings together pillars of the society that continue struggling with lack of conditions to conduct their entrepreneurial performance. Entrepreneurship sector in order to be successful, needs to have a buying force which is decreasing in Western Balkans, at the same time the labour force is looking forward to contribute more in European market rather than staying in WB. This joint initiative aims to enhance regional cooperation, strengthen regional cohesion through economic cooperation in the WB6 region. Through this initiative we aim to strengthen regional investment potentials through strengthening market linkages, networking and business partners in the Western Balkan and to exchange knowledge and experiences among chambers and businesses.

Target Groups

SMEs, companies, export-oriented, self-employed, processors, start-ups, crafts, research institutions, intermediary organisations and local municipalities, public authorities, business associations and bilateral chambers. Business communities, including women business associations/chambers, professional chambers.

Partner 1- Economic Chamber of North West Macedonia

Partner 2 - Chamber of Economy of Montenegro





Bišćepolje bb 88 000 Mostar



Cover Picture, courtesy of INTERA

The project contributes to regional and cross-border cooperation through an innovative approach to sustainable tourism growth and economic development. The project builds a network of NGOs (and local authorities) in Western Balkans in order to share their experiences in environmental protection and of actions that can be taken and to facilitate cooperation in the future.



Innovation and Entrepreneurship
Center Tehnopolis

PROAKTIV



Regional co-working managers,
coworkers, digital nomads, freelancers,
startups, SMEs, relevant local, regional
and national public authorities



Co-funded by
the European Union



AGORA

16-1/7 Aminta Treti Street, 1000 Skopje

The project Leap to Success is a 4-month regional project where three organizations from three different Contracting Parties join their forces in order to contribute to the regional development and providing better future for the youth in the respective CP's. With this joint effort it is aimed at stimulating and promoting youth entrepreneurship in these three CP's. This overall objective matches with both areas of intervention of this WBF Call, the education and scientific exchange and sustainable development and promotes knowledge-based entrepreneurship as source of growth and job creation, as well as it promotes initiatives for inclusive and sustainable economic growth.



Target Group

Youth between 18 to 29 years who have business idea(s) and are interested in starting their new business.

Partners

Metropolitan Incubator
Deli space for creative activity



Brigada VIII, Pallati 6/2. Kati V. Tirana

Project brings together regional CSO to participate and cooperate together over major sustainability issues that confront their communities, separately and as community inhabiting a shared space in Western Balkans. The cross-border communities share natural resources of primary importance for their continued existence: waters, forests and agricultural lands, resources now impacted by climate change and poor waste management. Forest fires, illegal logging and hunting and poor waste management are affecting biodiversity and availability and quality of natural resources supporting community activities. The project arose naturally from the realization that much work to address sustainable development has been undertaken in individual projects implemented by NGOs and local governments. Whereas central government agencies and local governments have received training in certain aspects covered by the call, many CSOs still need to benefit from these experiences. Sharing this wide range of experiences will fill a gap in the potential for actions to be taken (even voluntarily) by separate members of a community, by a community together, and by communities working together.

In partnership with

Agency for Management of
Protected Areas of Podgorica

Environment and Youth Capacity
Development, EYCD

Target Audience

30 NGOs from dealing natural promotion and preservation
3 local authorities

Public agencies in selected CPs





5th Call for Proposals

At the time of this publication (September 2022), the 5th Call for Proposals is in the middle of the demanding evaluation phase. However, the 5 CfP has already made history as the largest Call ever launched in terms of financial support and the number of supported projects. This time, our Regional Grant Scheme will back 36 projects, shared equality between Contracting Parties.

For the Western Balkans Fund, it is the first time since our establishment that launch two Call for Proposals six months apart. This would not have been possible without the added support of our Ministries, the Contracting Parties and the European Union, which co-funds the fourth and the fifth Call for Proposals through IPA – Instrument for Pre-Accession Assistance.

The 5 CfP was launched on 20 May 2022, when the Online Grant Application Portal became accessible to all potential beneficiaries, remaining open until midnight between 8-9 July. The Awarding Ceremony is expected to be held in late autumn.

Info Session

Like the previous CfP, the WBF team embarked on a regional tour, stopping at 12 locations, 2 per contracting party. From 30 May to 10 June 2022, we visited Belgrade, Nis, Podgorica, Niksic, Prishtina, Mitrovica, Skopje, Tetovo, Sarajevo, Tuzla, Tirana and Shkodra.

Info Days

For the first time, under the 5th Call for Proposals, we piloted the Info Days, in which a selected team member contacted potential stakeholders in a different location from those of the Info Sessions. Banja Luka, Zenica, Mostar, Novi Sad and Kragujevac were the destinations of this successful exercise.

Mentorship Session

Western Balkans Fund provided the opportunity to reach out to WBF remotely in every official language in the region to better accommodate the needs of the Civil Society Organisations and other regional stakeholders. On 22-23 June, Mentorship Sessions in Bosnian, Croatian, Serbian, Montenegrin, Albanian, Macedonian and English provided additional support for 161 enrolled participants.

The largest Call in
WBF history



European Union co-funds the 5th Call for Proposals, through IPA - Instrument for Pre-Accession Assistance

500.000 €

Budget available

36

Projects to be supported

In mid-June, the Western Balkans Fund was able to award six more projects. Divided equally between our Contracting Parties, the projects tackle sexual harassment, social inclusion, marginalization, and contribute to best practices exchange and sustainable development through green tourism. The Awarding Ceremony took place in Hotel Rogner International in Tirana, in the presence of WB6 and V4 ambassadors, diplomatic corps, partners and other distinguished guests.

Six more project supported financially



ApsArt Centre for Theater Research based in Belgrade, with the project "The Hardest Role"

This project is about actresses and women in the performing arts to present the long-kept truth about the normalization of sexual harassment and abuse in our environment, both in the professional sphere and in the wider public discourse. To combine not only our experiences but also creative potential and specific artistic expressions in an effort to tell this complex and difficult story.

Center for Energy, Environment and Resources (Cener 21) with the project "Young WB Ambassadors of Positive Change"

This project focuses on strengthening the capacity of young people to develop sustainable consumption systems in order to adapt appropriately to climate change. Given that the CPs of the Western Balkans are characterized by intensive linear consumer habits, where resources are enormously depleted, it is necessary to implement activities in order to increase the awareness and capacity of youth about changing the habits of traditional consumption.

Paragliding Sky Riders Prilep,
"Birds perspective from Balkan Sky"

The proposed Initiative aims to promote and brand the gliding sport, to enhance interest in this sport, especially among young people and to increase Aero Clubs membership. The project additionally focuses on air pollution in order to raise public awareness and understanding of this problem that affects Balkan countries terribly.

ApsArt Ce Association of Youth with disabilities of Montenegro, with the project "Articulate Inclusion"

The project aims to contribute to the increase of level of participation of persons with disabilities in cultural life of the Western Balkans countries. This aim could be achieved through development of at least one program for artistic development of PWDs and exchange of experience of artists with disabilities and artists without disabilities and by raising awareness of the public on importance of participation of PWDs in the cultural life

SpaceSyntax Ks, based in Prishtina, with the project "Geotaggers"

"Geo-Taggers" is a project that organizes its main work around facilitating an annual educational program focusing in the fields of geospatial data. The program will focus on delivering the necessary skillsets and knowledge for the youth of Western Balkan Region that will enable them to follow the newest trends of geospatial data and make use of the relevant technologies.

People in Focus Albania, based in Tirana,
"WB Summer School – First Edition"

Contracting Parties have many resources referring to tourism which can lead to bridges of communication and create collaboration fruitful to our countries. Events representing each other identity through tourism will help to understand better ourselves and raise sense of community. Youth will open discussion on the problems, questions and try to find answers on how to make visible all the potential of WB tourism and to find solution to begin advocacy initiative on the future.



BEYOND GRANTS

Fire Conference, a commitment to fight hate speech and discrimination everywhere in WB Region

"Promote Culture of Tolerance and Mutual Respect within two regions" Regional Conference is a product of Western Balkans Fund metamorphosing into an organisation that provides much more than grants.

In cooperation with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan and the International Visegrad Fund, Western Balkans Fund implemented the biggest regional conference of 2022, targeting hate speech and defamation.

Although a relatively new topic in Western Balkans, hate speech and defamation has already attracted a lot of media attention and public debate in both regions.



3

DAYS
1-3 March
2022

7

Panels
In fixed,
dynamic
and joins
spaces

43

Panelists
media outlets,
governments, thinks
tanks, civil society, self-
regulatory bodies,
judicial bodies etc

60

Experts
Participated in at
least one of the
panels of the
Conference

63

Recommendations
To governments,
public institutions,
media, civil society
and WBF

3.302

Guests
Including many
from important
institutions, media
and CSOs



- Erion Veliaj
- Nikola Dimitrov
- Uran Ismaili
- Karolina Zbytniewska
- Igor Bandović
- Norbert Šinković
- Milena Vučelić
- Ledion Krisafi
- Darko Soković
- Ksenija Vukmirović
- Elena Cherniavska

- Kristina Gadže
- Sanja Todorović
- Davor Marko
- Scott Griffen
- Biljana Nasteska Kalanoska
- Haris Čutahija
- Shejla Fidani
- Miloš Prica

- Nidžara Ahmetašević
- Leon Malazogu
- Veronika Bundzíkova
- Nikola Burazer
- Fitore Rexhepi
- Kaltrina Ajeti
- Urška Umek
- Sunčica Bakić
- Flutura Kusari
- Peter Grk

- Arben Muka
- Tanja Tomik
- Maja Raicevic
- Besa Luci
- Jiří Němec
- Amila Ždralović
- Fatjona Mejdini
- Milena Stosic Ivan Vejvoda
- Besnik Tahiri
- Alba Çela
- Endrit Shabani



However, there is still a lack of consistency, and awareness, on the definition of the topic, its amplitude and implications for all the actors involved, beginning with the people affected by it and the ones that are expected to combat it.

Through seven panels over three days, more than 60 international experts united in Tirana to explore sustainable, innovative and far-reaching solutions and tools.

63 recommendations deriving from panel discussions aimed at tackling hate speech head-on. Six months after the conclusion of FIRE Conference, we are encouraged to ascertain that many of the recommendations yield concrete results.

“

I learned that many interesting topics discussed extensively, especially about the impact of hate speech on the members of vulnerable groups, such as young people suffering from cyberbullying, or women being subjected to gender-based discrimination. This conference also touches upon the use of hate speech as a means to incite violence, undermine social cohesion and tolerance, and promote xenophobia, racism, antisemitism, anti-Muslim hatred.

As these phenomena are becoming more common across in the world, and human rights are being threatened more and more. So promoting a culture of tolerance and mutual respect within two regions, the Western Balkans and the Visegrad is becoming more important than ever.

Ambassador of Japan to Albania, H.E. Takada



55.000
Impressions

120.000
People
reached through socials



PANELS

Hate speech and cyber bullying as global (anti)culture

Hate speech a potential disturbance towards social cohesion

Hate speech a potential disturbance towards social cohesion

The defamation's risks and ways to deal with it

Regulating Hate Speech in the Media

Hate speech in political communication

How does Hate Speech affect Regional Cooperation

Networking with and beyond the WB Region

Even with COVID19 and all its challenges which changed the sense of normality and limited mobility, WBF has continued to put significant efforts to nurture its professional connections throughout the region. Some of the meetings and promotional actions that occurred during the reporting period are as follows:

On June 18, the WBF ED, WBF Senior Program Manager Ms. Beqiri and WBF Program Manager, Ms. Vukmirović, were welcomed in a working dinner by H.E. Mr. Mitsuyuki Takada, Ambassador of Japan to Albania at his residency.

On June 23, the WBF Secretariat welcomed Ms. Siëndrra Mehmëti, from Tetovo, North Macedonia as the new intern within its Internship program.

WBF Executive Director took part as one of speakers at the training "The challenges of Albania within the process of EU integration" organised by The Diplomatic Academy of Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs of Albania on June 25th.

WBF Executive Director attended the meeting of the Ministers of Foreign Affairs of the V4 and WB6 countries, in Poznan, Poland, on the June 28th, during which the Memorandum of Understanding between International Visegrad Fund and Western Balkans Fund was signed.

On June 28, WBF ED participated at the Joint V4 WB6 Ministerial in Poznan, where also the 3rd MoU between WBF and IVF was signed.

On July 1st the Swiss Ambassador Adrian Maître and Executive Director of the Western Balkans Fund, Dr. Gjergj Murra, have signed the Agreement, with which outlines the 5 year support to WBF in order to boost cooperation and increase exchanges in the region.

On July 8, WBF ED attended the 5th Anniversary of the Regional Youth Cooperation Office.

On July 21st WBF Executive Director had a meeting with Mm. Elisabeth Barsacq, French Ambassador to Albania where they discussed the regional cooperation and the achievements of WBF.

On July 28th, WBF ED welcomed in a working lunch the Ambassadors of Switzerland to Albania, Ambassador of Japan to Albania, Ambassador of the Republic of North Macedonia to Albania and the General Director of the Albanian MFA.

On July 29th, WBF ED and Mrs. Serafimova, WBF NM Chairmanship in Office met in Skopje with Mr. Marko Troshanovski - Institute for Democracy Societas Civilis Skopje to further discuss the developments of the Think Balkans Program.

On August 30th and 31st, WBF ED and Mr. Jankovic, WBF member of Council of Senior Officials met in Belgrade with Mr. Laszlo Jonas from the Design Terminal, to further discuss the Western Balkans Start Up Concept.

On September 9th, On the occasion of the fourth anniversary of WBF, a grand reception was organised, attended by ambassadors and diplomatic representatives of the WBF Contracting Parties, EU member states, Japan, Switzerland, and members of the civil society. Partners from all over the region joined in Tirana to celebrate the 4 years of achievements and success of WBF.



On September 17th, WBF hosted a new member of WBF Council of Senior Officials from Prishtina, Mr. Albinot Bimbashi to discuss views on regional cooperation processes.

On 11-12 October, the software developers of GoEasy organised a training session on the Online Grant Management System for the WBF Team.

On October 12, WBF Executive Director took part on-line and made a keynote speech at the international conference "2021 Slovenian Presidency with the Council of EU, the integration of WB and the role of the Visegrad countries" in Ljubljana.

On October 15-16, a delegation headed by IVF Director, Ambassador Petr Mares and Deputy Director, Marianna Neupairova visited WBF headquarters. During the meetings, it was discussed on the excellent cooperation to date and possible ways to enhance the partnership further in the future.

On October 26th, the Ambassador of Serbia to Albania, His Excellency Mr. Slobodan Vukcevic, paid a visit to the WBF headquarters.

On October 28, WBF Executive Director met with Deputy Minister of Foreign Affairs, Ms. Fatmira Isaki, his Excellency, Ambassador Dancho Markovski at the WBF Secretariat premises.

On November 8th, WBF ED organised a Call with the representatives of the Design Terminal regarding the possibility of WBF to support the Start-up force extension to the Western Balkans.

Supporting Partners Growth

On November 26th, WBF ED organised a working lunch with the head of the Think Balkans consortium, Mr. Marko Trosanovski to discuss regarding the Consortium's development and latest operations and on the possibility of WBF to support part of the project in the upcoming period.

On January 21, WBF ED organised a virtual Meeting with the IVF Executive Director and IVF DED to discuss on the continuation of the cooperation, in the framework of the Third Memoranda of Cooperation and Third Technical Assistance Program.

On 4th of February, WBF participated at the Tirana European Youth Capital 2022 organised by the Municipality of Tirana.

On 17th of February, WBF visited The Social Centre to Help People in Need in Fushe Arrez Albania. Western Balkans Fund supported the cabinet of the Centre by donating computers, a printer, and other supporting materials.

On 24th of February, WBF ED met in Budapest with the Ministerial Commissioner for the Hungarian Presidency of V4 Group, Madam Krisztina Varju and the V4HUPRES team: Mr. Andras Lazar, National V4 Coordinator and Ms. Nora Kertesz, Desk Officer for V4 and IVF coordination.

On 25th of February, the WBF ED attended the Budapest Balkans Forum

On 25th of February, WBF Senior Program Manager attended the Regional Youth Leadership Mobility Program Launching event, organised by the Science & Development Center (SciDEV)

On March 1st, WBF Ed met with Ambassador Ms. Suzana Boskovič-Prodanovič – on behalf of WBF Belgrade Chairmanship in Office –2022 and Mr. Pavle Jankovic, Head of regional initiatives.

On March 9th, WBF ED met with Assistant Minister at the MFA of Bosnia and Herzegovina, ambassador Ahmet Halilovic;

On 23rd of March, three WBF team members participated in the Visegrad's Fund evaluation session of the Visegrad + projects.

On 26 of April, the Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary Ambassador of Israel to Albania, H.E. Noah Gal Gendler, visited the Western Balkans Fund Secretariat.

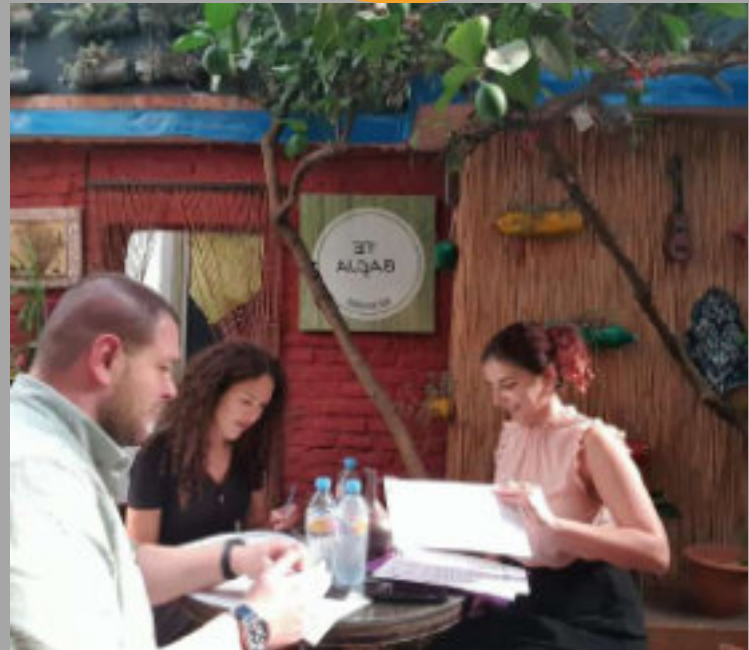
On 15 of May, WBF ED participated in the 7th Annual Forum of the European Union Strategy for the Adriatic and Ionian Region.

On 27 May, WBF and Luarasi University held a joint public ceremony, in which they officially signed a memorandum of understanding.

On 2 June, a WBF team was received by the Director of Culture, Youth and Sport in Municipality of Mitrovica, Ms. Valdete Idrizi.

On 6 June, WBF MEL Officer appeared in a TV interview in Serbia.

On 27 June, Ms. Beqiri represented WBF at the prestigious UN Habitat Forum, with a keynote speech at the "Regional Perspectives of Urban Talks" panel.



Mentoring visit, Fjordi Bisha (I), Valbona Dedja and Iris Murati (FLAG)

Despite the impressive amount of workload carried by our small team, the Western Balkans Fund remained committed to conducting monitoring and evaluation of its grants. During the 4th Call for Proposals, we decided to be everywhere in the region and to meet with every grantee, in order to maximise the impact of our joint action.

Moreover, monitoring, PR and representation visits are a good tool of internal capacity building, enabling WBF to consistently strive for excellence in how it conducts its operations.

In order to deliver on its strategic ambitions, WBF decided to invest in the development of a tailored monitoring, evaluation and learning (MEL) system. Since February, our team includes a new position on its organigram, the MEL Officer, a duty that is currently held by Mr. Uroš Čitaković. The system is intended to contribute to WBF's programmatic development, improve the effectiveness of its grant-making programming and outcomes, and increase accountability.



As of September 2022, the Western Balkans Fund cooperates closely with six strategic partners: the European Union, the Swiss Government, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, the International Visegrad Fund, Peace Nexus and RYCO. June 21-June 22 timeline brought substantial improvements in bilateral relations with all of our partners.

PARTNER STRATEGIC

European Union - With the support provided by the EU, the WBF was able to launch the two largest Calls for Proposals since its establishment, the 4th (launched Nov. 21) and 5th (launched May 22). Thanks to the EU, our staff has expanded to include four new colleagues. Mr. Fjordi Bisha, in the capacity of Project Manager. Mr. Klevis Gjoni was recruited in September in the position of Public Relations Officer. Ms. Juliana Muço, recruited in October in the position of FAO. In February 22, Uros Citakovic joined the team in the capacity of MEL Officer.

Swiss Government - Upon conclusion of the Partner risk assessment process and the definition of the action plan addressing aspects with potential to be improved, on 1st of July 2021 the contract between SDC and Western Balkans Fund was signed in Tirana. Through this support, the Swiss grants the WBF a core contribution of maximum CHF 950'000 as participation towards the WBF Budget for the period from 05.07.2021-31.12.2025. Thanks to this precious support, the WBF is currently diversifying its grant portfolio, including many new types of intervention that will benefit the Civil Society Organisations in the Western Balkans Region.

Peace Nexus. WBF Secretariat continues to enjoy the precious support of PeaceNexus in terms of coordination of WBF's activities and definition of the WBFs needs for the Secretariats' work improvement and fundraising efforts. Thanks to that support, WBF is continuing to develop its grant-making practice. A direct benefit is the roll-out of a sound Monitoring Evaluation and Learning framework. This keynote document backs a sound and sustainable growth of our organisation in the future. In the reporting period of this annual report, PN engaged in developing a WBF Financial Management Policy and a Legal and Human Resources Consultancy.

Ministry of Foreign Affairs Japan. WBF and Japan renewed their cooperation with FIRE Conference, the largest regional event of 2022 that tackles hate speech and discrimination. In the eve of the successful FIRE event, we have agreed to extend our partnership with yet another big event that will be unveiled in a second moment within this year.

